The Property Known as Garland

By Billy Van Zandt

SETTING: *Star dressing room -- Falconre Center, Copenhagen, Denmark, March 25, 1969.*

VOICE: **(Pg 7)** Miss Garland? Miss Garland? One hour, Miss Garland.

INTRODUCTION

According to Fred Astaire, Judy Garland was "the greatest entertainer who ever lived." But how did she become such a talented, internationally beloved, living legend? Through diet, nicotine, orthodontics, and drugs -- stimulants to keep her going and depressants to help her sleep -- Judy Garland was created to be a movie money maker. She worked 18 hours a day, 6 days a week as "the property" of MGM, sacrificing her soul to a ravenous public and uncaring industry in exchange for fleeting moments of joy found in front of the camera and on stage.

Her talent was legendary. Her story, more electrifying than you'd ever imagine. In this fictional account, Miss Garland takes us down the yellow brick road of her incredible life. It is March 1969, backstage at a theatre in Copenhagen as Judy Garland prepares for another star performance. In fact, this turns out to be her last concert: she tragically dies of a drug overdose three months later.

Born Frances Ethel Gumm, she became . . . The Property Known as Garland by Billy Van Zandt

JUDY: **(Pg 12-13)** *(JUDY's mind drifts. She takes her cigarette and crosses to the dressing table . . distant)* I have no intention of going on tonight. *(Pours drink and toasts herself)* Hello. I'm Judy Garland and I'm an alcoholic. Can you imagine? *(Laughs)* One of my husbands took me to an AA meeting once. Because he was a drunk! It was so – funny. He got livid because I sat there the entire meeting with a flask of Chivas on my lap. While all those people went on and on about how miserable their lives were. I mean, really. I'll tell you why they were all so miserable. They needed a drink. That would've cheered them right up. Did you ever go to one of those things? You just sit there and sit there and listen to these tortured souls spilling out their troubles like a "who-has-the-most-pathetic-story contest." Ye-Gods.

(Pg 15-17) *(Judy stares at herself in the mirror)* I have a very strange body. I'm all legs with this hump thing here and no neck to speak of. But I do have a lovely nose. Don't you think? I have good eyebrows. And a good nose. That's not much to go on. Mr. Louis B. Mayer,

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who ran Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer . . . used to refer to me as "the fat one" and "the hunchback." And not behind my back either. He'd do it right on the set. He'd say, "Do you see this little girl? Look what a star I've turned her into. She used to be a fat little hunchback. Isn't that right, Judy?" And I'd have to answer, "Why, yes, Mr. Mayer. I suppose it is." So I have a bit of an inferiority complex about my looks. When I auditioned for M-G-M, I was thirteen years old, and someone asked my mother why I had never been under contract to a studio before, and –

ETHEL GUMM: Take a good look at her and figure it out for yourself.

JUDY: So, you see. I'm just a hopeless case. My entire career people have been trying to find ways to camouflage me, or make me pretty. They've put rubber pieces in my nose and capped my crooked teeth and changed my hairline and my color. They stuffed me into canvas body stockings to give me a waist. They put shoulder pads here and here. And when I did my TV show, they even built me a, well, a "rear end." I may have million dollar legs, but in some trunk somewhere I also have a six hundred dollar ass.

But I do what they tell me. I'm conditioned. *(Taking sip)* Back at Metro, my primary function was to work. As long as I worked, the studio's investment in the "property known as Garland" paid off. If I got fat I couldn't work. And therefore I couldn't get fat. *(Judy stands next to the dressing table)* They had this clothes dummy at the studio – a great, fat clothes dummy. And they'd make me stand next to it and stare into the mirror.

STUDIO BOSS: Take a good look at yourself, Judy. Now look at this big, fat, clothes dummy. Which one do you want to be? A big fat dummy, or a star?

YOUNG JUDY: I want to be a star.

STUDIO BOSS: Good girl. From now on make sure she gets nothing but chicken soup in the commissary.

JUDY: And that's what they gave me. Every day at noon. For thirteen years. Chicken soup. And water. Like a prisoner's menu. Now? Even the sight of a chicken? Instant throw-up.

It's a chore being Judy Garland. You know how many people pull at me? Demand things of me? Write about me? How many drag queens imitate me? How many people tell my

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children they know me? They know me. They know Judy Garland. "Poor Judy. She tried to kill herself over four thousand times, you know."

Well, I'm not as helpless as people think! I'm really not. **(Pg 18)** I'm not in Kansas anymore, folks. But no one wants to hear that. I'll always be Dorothy Gale – just can't get away from "her."

MAN: Could you sign this for my daughter?

JUDY: Of course, darling. *(Flashes as a camera goes off)*

VOICE: Judy/Judy/Over here! *(More flashes)* Judy! / One picture? / One more!

JUDY: Thank you, pussycat. *(Flash of a camera)* I am so sick of saying thank you! *(Beat)* I've spent years and years and years trying to please people. My mother. Mr. Mayer. You! And no matter how hard I try, I'm constantly written about like I'm some sort of unfit person. Well, I'm not. I'm not! I'm not some sort of a joke. Yet people think I'm either a drunk, or a drug addict or. . . It's a Goddamned wonder I'm not! But I'm not. I'm just me.

(Pg 19) *(sarcastically)* I made my debut in 1782. Back home in Grand Rapids where I was born. My darling father owned the theater there. And our whole family performed in vaudeville between the movies. Back then I was Baby Gumm. I was four years old. My mother was a hideous wicked woman. I was just a child, but that never mattered. If I was sick or something and didn't want to go onstage, she didn't care. She'd just say, "Get out there and sing or I'll wrap you round the bedpost and break you off short!" Joan Crawford had nothing on her, believe me.

(Pg 21-24) When we lived in Lancaster . . . California? . . . if I got too much applause during our shows, my sisters would catch jars full of bees and then after the show, they'd lock me in a room and open the jars.

I had to survive Mother cheating on my darling father with our next-door neighbor. A ghastly made man who eventually left his paralyzed stroke-victim wife for my mother. A match made in hell. I loathed him.

YOUNG JUDY: How can you do this to Daddy?

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ETHEL GUMM: Do what to Daddy?

YOUNG JUDY: I know what goes on with you and Mr. Gilmore

ETHEL GUMM: You don't know as much as you think you do.

YOUNG JUDY: What don't I know?

ETHEL GUMM: Your father is a homosexual, Judy. Why do you think we left Grand Rapids?

JUDY: Imagine telling a five-year-old girl that about her father. There's the real Wicked Witch of the West. *(Judy begins to prepare her make-up for the stage)* Two months after I signed with Metro, Daddy went to the hospital with what turned out to be spinal meningitis. I didn't know how bad it was or I would've spent every second by his side. But Mother didn't tell me.

ETHEL GUMM: You go do your radio job, Judy. Never mind, Daddy. He'll be fine. We don't want M-G-M to think you're difficult, now do we?

YOUNG JUDY: But Mama . . .

ETHEL GUMM: Judy, do you know what it took for me to get you this goddamn studio contract? How many fat, hunchbacked girls do you think they're signing over there? Now get in the car and go sing.

JUDY: Right before I went on the air, I got a phone call saying they were placing a radio beside Daddy's bed. And right then I knew. Daddy was dying. *(Proudly)* And so I went on. And I sang for Daddy for the last time.

* YOUR EYES MADE THE SKY SEEM BLUE AGAIN
WHAT ELSE COULD I DO AGAIN
BUT KEEP REPEATING
THROUGH AND THROUGH
I LOVE YOU, LOVE YOU . . . . .

It was the song I auditioned for M-G-M with. And one of the first songs Daddy ever taught me. . . . Daddy died the next morning.

Life's very peculiar. Mother married Mr. Gilmore on November 17, 1939. It was her forty-sixth birthday. And the anniversary of my father's death. That was the most awful thing

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that ever happened to me. My mother marrying that awful man the same date that my Daddy died. **(Pg 25)** The only nice thing I will say about my mother is that she taught me not to be cruel to my own children. I should be grateful for that, I suppose. After my darling Daddy died, M-G-M more or less adopted me.

(Pg 36) They worked us six days a week from eight in the morning until three in the morning – for fifteen straight years. You'd finish one picture on Saturday and start your next picture on Monday. It was a schedule no one should've had to endure. Least of all a thirteen-year-old girl. And I had no one to fight for me. My darling father was gone. My mother did as she was told. *(sips her wine)* **(Pg 37)** That's when they started giving me pills to keep me awake, and pills to go to sleep. And diet pills. They gave them to everybody. To keep us going, you know? Everyone thinks it's such a "Garland" thing, but every actor in Hollywood took them.

(Pg 40) She never watched out for me, my mother. Never. After sixteen years and no time off, I was at the end of my rope. I was holding on by a thread, mind you. And they put me into another picture . . . "Annie Get Your Gun." Just to get out of work one day, I slashed my wrists. Not deep. But enough. It was all very hysterical. There was blood everywhere. And people were screaming. But I did get the day off! *(Beat)* And then for no Goddamn reason at all, they fired me.

(Pg 41) Is it any wonder I ended up in a "nuthouse"? My very first – you always remember your first, don't you? -- They put me in my own little bungalow *(Framing her face with her hands, a la "A Star is Born")* – I was a movie star, after all. The entire time I was in there, my mother only called me once.

ETHEL GUMM: There's something wrong with your brain, do you know that?

JUDY: Wicked old witch. *(Beat)* **(Pg 44)** What do you do after you give everything there is to give and it's not good enough? Well, I just fell apart. *(She laughs)* **(Pg 47)** What have I learned from all this? *(Thinks, then)* Hell if I know. I'm just lucky I'm still here, I guess. All in all, I'm a very lucky woman. *(Rising)* I've got my children. I have my audiences. And for

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once in my life, I'm finally with a man who loves me. Me. Not my voice – because it's gone. Not my money – because I didn't have any when I met him, and I don't have any now. He loves ME. Whether I sing or dance or whether I don't. And he thinks I'm pretty. *(finishes lipstick, into mirror)* Me. Pretty. You hear that, Mama? *(Beat)*

(Pg 49) Recently, one of the reporters asked me if I'd do it all over again. "You bet your life, Buster. With all the same mistakes, too." I was put on this earth to give. To give my heart and soul to my audiences. I can't do any less. I really can't. I never will. *(She hears applause from stage area)* You'll never know this kind of love, Mama. It's the one thing you couldn't take from me. *(Motions off)* That's mine! They love me. Hunchback and crooked teeth and insecurities and all. And that love is mine! Alone! I love them! And I need them! But you know something? They need me too! *(Judy enters the stage)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier - MS
NIETOC
CA State Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

* http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uuxyNym5zpk
-- Judy Garland singing Zing! Went the Strings of My Heart

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